

before the first gun arrives. The closest the army is to buying a howitzer is self-propelled guns. Trials of wheeled artillery guns are to be held in October this year and a decision is likely to be taken by next year. Global Request for Proposals (RFPs) are to be issued to import tracked self-propelled guns in November this year.

In June this year, when the CBI alleged the involvement of Singapore arms manufacturer ST Kinetics in bribes paid to the former chairman of

ultra-light categories, further limiting the army's choice.

This appears to be a familiar pattern where guns are concerned. Blacklisting Bofors dealt the first blow to the army's field artillery rationalisation programme. A contract to manufacture over 1,000 FH-77B guns indigenously was scrapped. The Government crackdowns have come at a point when the army has come close to finalising a contract. In 2005, when South Africa's Denel was close to

says a senior bureaucrat.

The ostensible reason is that the DPP forbids single vendor situations and calls for competition to ensure the country gets the best buy and one company does not dictate terms to the MOD. Both these premises are unfounded say defence experts because when manufacturers submit their bids they are unlikely to know they are single vendors. "Invariably the number of competitors who will meet the army's exacting requirement will



AN INDIAN ARMY FH-77B HOWITZER IN ACTION

the Ordnance Factory Board, a contract for the supply of 145 ultra-light howitzers worth Rs 2,900 crore was scrapped. "We see no reason for suspending trials when the allegations are yet to be proven and when existing contracts continue for companies blacklisted in the same investigation," says Gaius Ho, spokesperson for ST Kinetics. Each time it blacklists a firm, the Ministry of Defence (MOD) further shrinks the number of howitzer manufacturers it can do business with. This often leads to the single vendor situation that the Defence Procurement Procedure (DPP) forbids. For instance, blacklisting ST Kinetics means the company cannot participate in the towed and

finalising a deal for 280 self-propelled howitzers, it was blacklisted following allegations of bribes paid to Indian officials for another contract to supply anti-material rifles. The self-propelled gun contracts were scrapped.

When the FH-77B could not make the final list following the last trials two years ago, the MOD announced fresh RFPs which meant restarting the entire system of trials, evaluations and negotiations. There are now just five companies left in the fray for the world's largest howitzer contract: BAe Systems, Israel's Soltam, France's Nexter and Germany's Rheinmetall and Korea's Samsung Techwin. "We are like silkworms, slowly spinning ourselves in procedural cocoons,"

be few. Instead of shooting ourselves in the foot by restarting the process, the MOD needs to clear such single vendor cases at the highest level," says Major General (retd.) Mrinal Suman. But after the Bofors experience, evidently no defence minister is willing to take that call. So the easier alternative is restarting the process. Sometimes, the army itself is to blame. When it sent out bids to upgrade the remaining 380 FH-77B guns in its inventory this year, the army drew up a list of specifications so stringent that the original manufacturers BAe Systems refused to respond. The net result? A stalled upgrade programme. Which is pretty much the case with the army's howitzer project. The painful gun saga never seems to end, much to the detriment of the army and the country. ■